transmitted per unit time or per second is called sound power. Therefore, the *intensity of sound* is defined as *"the sound power transmitted per unit area taken normal to the propagation of the sound wave "*.

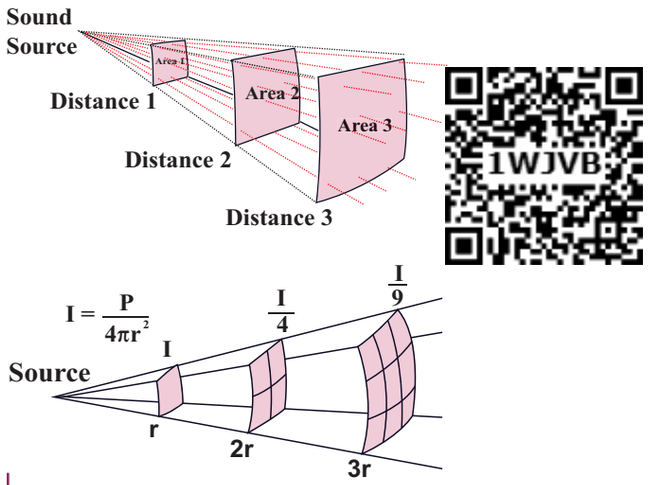


Figure 11.35 Intensity of sound waves

For a particular source (fixed source), the sound intensity is inversely proportional to the square of the distance from the source.

$$I = \frac{power\ of\ the\ source}{4\pi r^2} \Rightarrow I \propto \frac{1}{r^2}$$

This is known as inverse square law of sound intensity.

EXAMPLE 11.23

A baby cries on seeing a dog and the cry is detected at a distance of 3.0 m such that the intensity of sound at this distance is 10^{-2} W m^{-2}. Calculate the intensity of the baby's cry at a distance 6.0 m.

Solution

I_1 is the intensity of sound detected at a distance 3.0 m and it is given as 10^{-2} $W\ m^{-2}$. Let I_2 be the intensity of sound detected at a distance 6.0 m. Then,

$r_1 = 3.0$ m, $\quad r_2 = 6.0$ m

and since, $I \propto \frac{1}{r^2}$

the power output does not depend on the observer and depends on the baby. Therefore,

$$\frac{I_1}{I_2} = \frac{r_2^2}{r_1^2}$$

$$I_2 = I_1 \frac{r_1^2}{r_2^2}$$

$$I_2 = 0.25 \times 10^{-2}\ \text{W m}^{-2}$$

11.9.2 Loudness of sound

Two sounds with same intensities need not have the same loudness. For example, the sound heard during the explosion of balloons in a silent closed room is very loud when compared to the same explosion happening in a noisy market. Though the intensity of the sound is the same, the loudness is not. If the intensity of sound is increased then loudness also increases. But additionally, not only does intensity matter, the internal and subjective experience of "how loud a sound is" i.e., the sensitivity of the listener also matters here. This is often called loudness. That is, loudness depends on both intensity of sound wave and sensitivity of the ear (It is purely observer dependent quantity which varies from person to person) whereas the intensity of sound does not depend on the observer. The *loudness of sound* is defined as *"the degree of sensation of sound produced in the ear or the perception of sound by the listener"*.

11.9.3 Intensity and loudness of sound

Our ear can detect the sound with intensity level ranges from 10^{-2} Wm^{-2} to 20 $W\ m^{-2}$.

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